China Software: Aug revenue growth down to 6.5% YoY; AI native products in expansion to drive spending



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China software industry growth in August was +6.5% YoY (vs. Jul 2026/ Aug 2025 at +6.7%/ 15.0% YoY), faster than the prior month, leading to aggregate **8M26 revenue growth of +8.8% YoY** (vs. 8M25 at 12.6% YoY). Looking into 2H ahead, we expect to see sequential QoQ growth with better seasonality, while we see software spending remaining under pressure with allocation to AI foundational model and customized AI model projects. We see accelerated monetization and expanding use cases of AI agents, for example AI agents to retain experienced employees' know-how in-house, or diversify production sites with higher efficiency. With improving AI features, we see higher willingness of enterprise clients to use AI. For example, Beisen notes the high client interest on AI HR products incl. AI interview, AI E-learning etc. to save employees' efforts with better results.

We monitor AI product momentum, SMB PMI data, company hiring, profitability, and product iteration to track the path of software spending recovery in China. By segment, semi design, IT services, and cloud computing and big data outperformed in July, with IT services contributing the major revenues in the China software industry. The SMB PMI was up in Sep, showing sign of improvement of enterprise IT spending ahead. Read more: China AI Software Product Tracker.

Aug software industry growth remained weak; Sep SMB PMI MoM increased

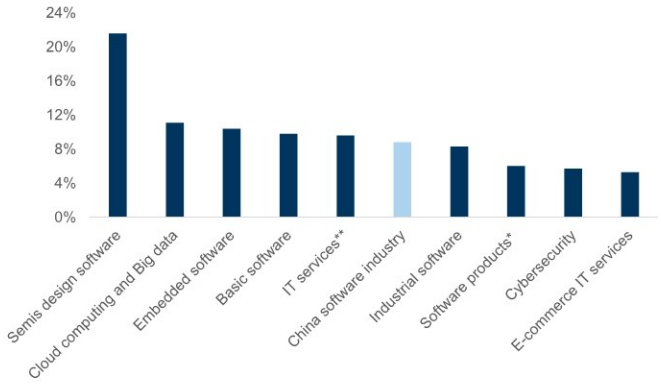
China software industry growth was down to 6.5% YoY in August 2026 (vs. 6.7% in Jul 2026), and the SMB PMI was up to 48.9 in Sep (vs. 47.4/ 47.9 in Jul/ Aug). We remain positive on better seasonality and rising AI adoption in 2H26, while overall the clients' software spending remained weak, and some projects were on AI foundational models and customized AI models. We see rising adoption of AI features, and expect to see new progress in foundational AI models for text/ image/ video content generation to drive the application ecosystem and drive clients' IT spending.

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China software sector key indicators:

- **China SMB PMI:** The PMI data reflects economic momentum and is correlated with the software market and customer budgets. In September 2026, SMB PMI increased to 48.9 from 47.9 in Aug (Exhibit 3).
- **Margin remained flat in Aug 2026:** We saw China software industry net margin at 11.1% in Aug vs. net margin at 11.1% in Jul, per MIIT.

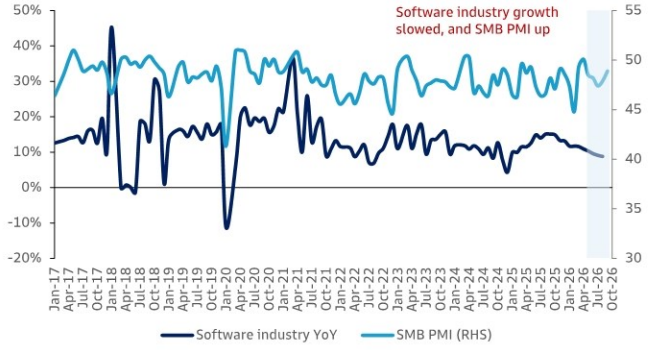
Exhibit 1: China software industry growth was at 8.8% YoY in 8M26
8M26 China Software industry revenue growth by segment



*software products include industrial software; **IT services include E-commerce IT services, semis design software, cloud computing and big data.

Source: MIIT

Exhibit 2: Software industry growth remained weak in Aug 2026; SMB PMI up in Sep 2026



Source: MIIT, NBS

Software Monthly: Aug revenues down to +6.5% YoY while MoM increase

August 2026 China software quick read:

1. **Revenue +6.5% YoY, leading to 8M26 at 8.8% YoY, slower than 7M26 growth of 9.1% YoY:** In August, the aggregate revenue of software companies registered in China was up +6.5% YoY to Rmb1.3trn (US$181bn), resulting in 8M26 revenue growth of +8.8% YoY, while going down from 7M26 of 9.1% YoY, per MIIT.
2. **Net margin was 11.1%, leading to 8M26 at 11.5%, lower vs. 7M26 of 11.6%:** In August, the aggregate net income of software companies registered in China was Rmb144.1bn (US$20.0bn), or net margin of 11.1% (vs. 11.1% in Aug 2026), resulting in 8M26 net margin of 11.5%, lower than 7M26 net margin of 11.6%, per MIIT.
3. **Overseas exposure down to 3.0%:** In August, the aggregate revenue for non-China markets from software companies registered in China was US$5.4bn, and overseas exposure decreased to 3.0% (vs. 3.9% in Jul 2026).
4. **IT services remain a key contributor:** In 8M26, the aggregate revenue of software companies registered in China (Rmb10.2trn) was mainly generated from IT services (69% of the total), followed by software products at 22%, embedded system software at 8%, and security software and services at 2%, per MIIT.

Exhibit 3: China software market snapshot

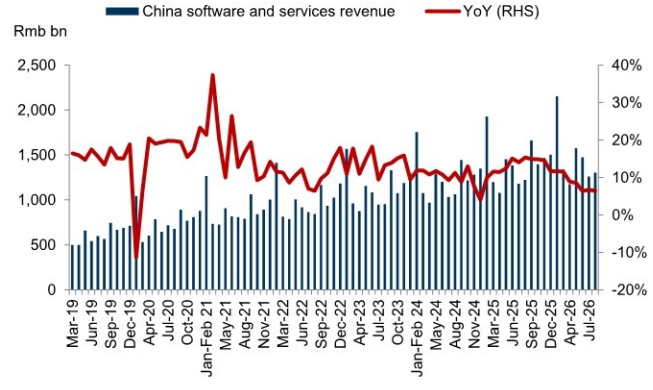
	Jul-25	Aug-25	Sep-25	Oct-25	Nov-25	Dec-25	Jan-Feb 26	Mar-26	Apr-26	May-26	Jun-26	Jul-26	Aug-26
China software market													
Total revenues (Rmb m)*	**1,181,340**	**1,224,141**	**1,662,397**	**1,397,700**	**1,467,300**	**1,505,500**	**2,153,500**	**1,338,500**	**1,176,600**	**1,576,400**	**1,473,100**	**1,260,400**	**1,303,500**
Software products	256,504	261,082	299,900	265,000	300,500	285,200	472,700	318,800	254,900	314,400	315,300	263,256	271,274
IT services	815,181	837,531	1,198,287	962,000	1,005,100	1,026,200	1,447,400	895,700	790,100	1,142,900	1,014,600	877,530	895,505
Security software	20,253	9,567	-1,175	18,300	19,100	23,400	41,200	24,800	20,800	23,400	32,300	21,375	9,341
Embedded system software	89,403	115,961	165,385	152,400	142,600	170,700	192,200	99,200	110,800	95,700	110,900	98,239	127,381
MoM	**-15%**	**4%**	**36%**	**-16%**	**5%**	**3%**			**-12%**	**34%**	**-7%**	**-14%**	**3%**
Software products	-13%	2%	15%	-12%	13%	-5%			-20%	23%	0%	-17%	3%
IT services	-14%	3%	43%	-20%	4%	2%			-12%	45%	-11%	-14%	2%
Security software	-34%	-53%	-112%	-1657%	4%	23%			-16%	13%	38%	-34%	-56%
Embedded system software	-17%	30%	43%	-8%	-6%	20%			12%	-14%	16%	-11%	30%
YoY	**14%**	**15%**	**15%**	**15%**	**15%**	**12%**	**12%**	**12%**	**9%**	**9%**	**6%**	**7%**	**6%**
Software products	11%	16%	8%	14%	13%	1%	8%	10%	6%	3%	7%	3%	4%
IT services	*16%*	*16%*	*18%*	*15%*	*16%*	*16%*	*13%*	*13%*	*9%*	*9%*	*7%*	*8%*	*7%*
Security software	*-5%*	*20%*	*7%*	*3%*	*11%*	*5%*	*6%*	*10%*	*5%*	*5%*	*6%*	*6%*	*-2%*
Embedded system software	8%	10%	9%	16%	6%	9%	12%	8%	14%	17%	2%	10%	10%
Mix	**100%**	**100%**	**100%**	**100%**	**100%**	**100%**	**100%**	**100%**	**100%**	**100%**	**100%**	**100%**	**100%**
Software products	22%	21%	18%	19%	20%	19%	22%	24%	22%	20%	21%	21%	21%
IT services	69%	68%	72%	69%	68%	68%	67%	67%	67%	73%	69%	70%	69%
Security software	2%	1%	0%	1%	1%	2%	2%	2%	2%	1%	2%	2%	1%
Embedded system software	8%	9%	10%	11%	10%	11%	9%	7%	9%	6%	8%	8%	10%
Total net income (Rmb m)*	**135,269**	**142,251**	**266,691**	**136,900**	**123,300**	**189,400**	**269,300**	**120,100**	**141,000**	**186,900**	**182,600**	**139,700**	**144,100**
MoM	-28%	5%	87%	-49%	-10%	54%							
YoY	15%	18%	-7%	-2%	-6%	14%	7%	-11%	6%	2%	-3%	3%	1%
Net margin	*11.5%*	*11.6%*	*16.0%*	*9.8%*	*8.4%*	*12.6%*	*12.5%*	*9.0%*	*12.0%*	*11.9%*	*12.4%*	*11.1%*	*11.1%*
Total revenues (Rmb m)	1,181,340	1,224,141	1,662,397	1,397,700	1,467,300	1,505,500	2,153,500	1,338,500	1,176,600	1,576,400	1,473,100	1,260,400	1,303,500
From China market	1,139,828	1,189,709	1,625,965	1,360,620	1,425,540	1,463,452	2,078,764	1,300,916	1,140,240	1,526,000	1,428,892	1,211,296	1,264,764
From non-China markets	41,513	34,432	36,432	37,080	41,760	42,048	74,736	37,584	36,360	50,400	44,208	49,104	38,736
Export ratio	**4%**	**3%**	**2%**	**3%**	**3%**	**3%**	**3%**	**3%**	**3%**	**3%**	**3%**	**4%**	**3%**

*Aggregate revenue/net income for software companies registered in China. IT services growth was mainly driven by cloud computing and big data segment.

Source: MIIT

Exhibit 4: China software market continued to grow in Aug 2026

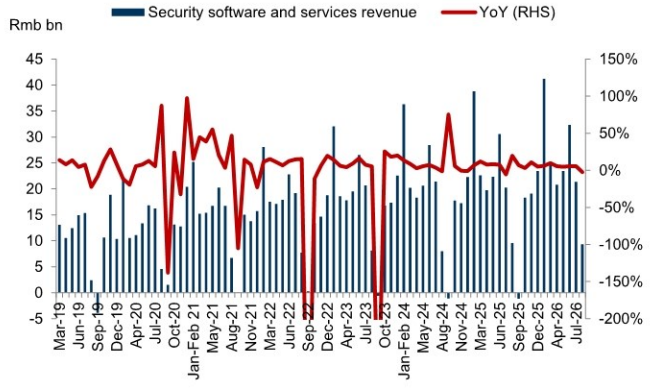
Software companies registered in China: aggregate revenues and YoY



Source: MIIT

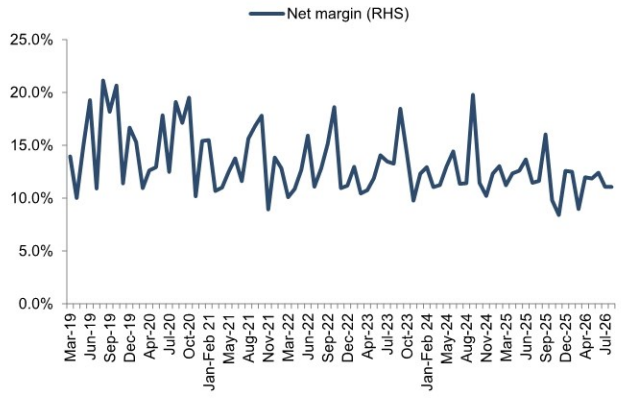
Exhibit 5: China security software revenues growth was at -2% YoY in Aug (vs. 6% YoY in Jul 2026)

Security software companies registered in China: aggregate revenues and YoY growth



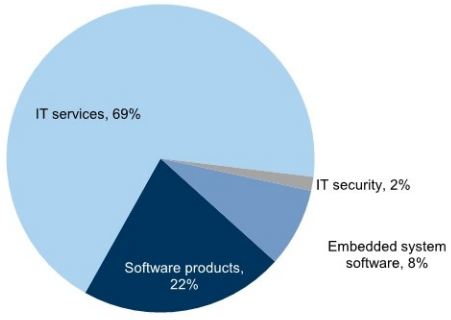
Source: MIIT

Exhibit 6: Net margin at 11.1% in Aug 2026 (vs. 11.1% in Jul 2026), leading to 8M26 NM at 11.5%
Software companies registered in China: aggregate NI YoY growth and net margin



Source: MIIT

Exhibit 7: IT services remain the key contributor
Software companies registered in China: aggregate revenues by subsector in 8M26

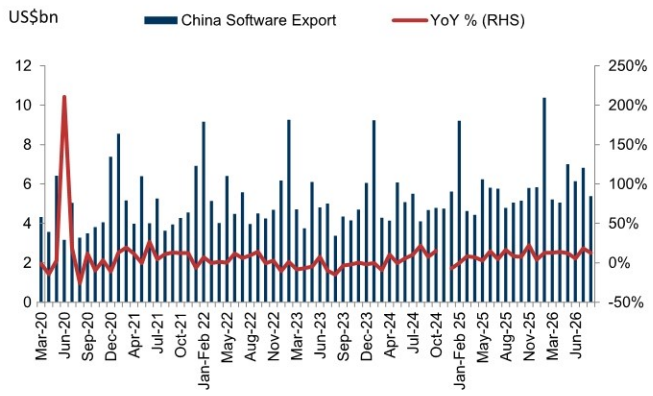


Source: MIIT

China security software / IT services market -2%/ +7% YoY in August 2026

- **China security software market revenue growth slowed in Aug:** In August, the aggregate revenue of security software companies registered in China was down 2% YoY to Rmb9.3bn (US$1.3bn), and 8M26 revenue came to Rmb173bn (US$24.1bn).
- **China IT services market revenue +7% YoY in August:** In August, the aggregate revenue of IT services companies registered in China was up 7% YoY to Rmb896bn (US$124bn), and 8M26 revenue came to Rmb7.1tn (US$981bn), per MIIT.
- **Service outsourcing contract value increased in August 2026:** In August, the aggregate contract value of service outsourcing was up (YoY) to Rmb119bn, and 8M26 contract value came to Rmb1,285bn, per Ministry of Commerce. The aggregate value of service outsourcing (execution) was up 37% YoY to Rmb88bn in August 2026, driven by rising AI-related projects.

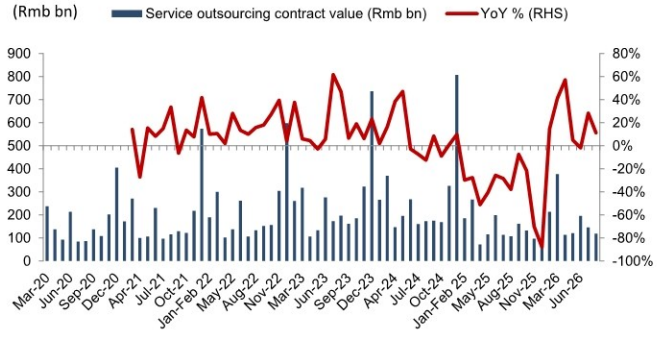
Exhibit 8: China service outsourcing contract value was up in August 2026



Source: Ministry of Commerce

Exhibit 9: Revenue from non-China markets went up in Aug (YoY)

Software companies registered in China: aggregate revenues from non-China markets



Source: MIIT

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